

Report

ENGL 7000-001

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Assignment: Editing Report

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Summary

The editing process for this publication project combined theoretical insights from a graduate-level editing course with practical application to produce a polished final product. Key theories, including rhetorical editing, genre conventions, and collaborative practices, shaped the approach to refining content and aligning it with audience expectations. These were complemented by principles of visual communication and layout design, ensuring accessibility and engagement.

The project highlighted the editor's multifaceted role in shaping content, collaborating effectively, and delivering a cohesive and purposeful publication. By integrating theoretical frameworks with hands-on practices, this process not only enhanced the final product's quality but also provided valuable insights into the transformative power of editing and the role of an editor.

Introduction: Bridging Theory and Practice

The editing process is a dynamic and collaborative endeavor that bridges theory and practice to transform raw ideas into a polished final product. This project showcases how a group of graduate students in Auburn University's Technical Editing course, guided by Dr. Derek Ross, applied editing principles and strategies to produce a refined publication.

Central to this effort was the integration of editing theories with practical applications. These principles guided the team in defining roles, planning and executing the editing process, and making stylistic and structural decisions. Iterative feedback and collaboration played a crucial role, highlighting how diverse perspectives enhanced the quality and clarity of the final work. This report details the strategies and techniques used, emphasising the transformative power of effective editing.

This project also drew upon contemporary approaches to publication design, integrating theories of visual communication and layout to ensure accessibility and engagement. This holistic approach demonstrates how editing is not merely about correcting errors but also about shaping a cohesive narrative that effectively communicates the intended message, aligns with the audience's needs, and enhances the overall impact of the content.

By bridging theoretical insights with hands-on application, this publication project reflects the multifaceted role of the editor in curating content, mediating, collaboration with colleagues, and delivering a product that meets both aesthetic and functional goals. Cunningham et al., further note that, "Technical editing involves more diverse audiences, new organisational roles, and a broader array of complex tools and modes of communication" (2019, p.1). This report explores the strategies and lessons learned during the editing process, demonstrating the critical balance between theory and application.

Starting the Publication

At the semester's start, Dr. Ross introduced the foundational principles and theories of editing, emphasising the role of an editor. We soon learned that we in fact would be organised into teams to create our own tangible publication by the end of the course—a project entirely under our control, in the role of an editor. Although I had experience creating publications, I quickly realised this project would require a deeper understanding of editing's complexities. As Cunningham et al. note, "A document arises from and is shaped by a particular rhetorical situation, involving communicators, audiences, and the document's purpose and format" (2019, p. 21). Our goal was to produce a tangible, clearly defined publication by the end of the semester.

Our four-member team decided to focus on plant life in and around Auburn, brainstorming ideas and unanimously agreeing on the name *Photo.Synthesis*. We then began defining our target audience—nature enthusiasts and individuals interested in local flora. The publication was designed to

serve as a practical guide to Auburn’s plant life while also encouraging creative contributions from readers.

Cunningham et al. asserts, “A document does not have a purpose independent of the people who create and use it” (2019, p. 23). Guided by this principle, we prioritised aligning the publication’s purpose with the audience’s needs and interests. We envisioned this publication fostering a sense of value and community among both contributors and readers. Above all, we understood that, as editors, our primary responsibility was “to advocate for readers and users of this document” (Cunningham et al., 2019, p. 20).

Planning the Project

Planning was crucial to ensuring the success of our publication. Without a clear strategy, editing could become “unfocused, cumbersome, and costly,” as Cunningham et al. cautioned (2019, p. 44). Recognising ourselves as novice editors, we had to devise a detailed editorial strategy to maintain efficiency and accuracy throughout the process of creating this publication. Additionally having a plan further allowed us to be guided during the creation, curation and distribution process of this publication.

Using Cunningham et al.’s framework, we identified the type, level, and scope of editing required for the project. Substantive editing focused on organisation and clarity, while copy editing refined grammar, punctuation, and style. Collaborative tools, such as box.com, allowed us to work simultaneously on documents both together and remotely.

Specialised Roles in Collaboration

While all team members served as editors, we each took on specialized roles to streamline the workflow. Cunningham et al. note, “that an editor’s primary responsibility is to ensure the accuracy, readability, organization, and standard formatting of documents. However, editors today often take on additional roles, such as writers, supervisors, translation managers, usability analysts, and information architects” (2019, p. 3).

In our team, I focused on substantive editing and copyediting, Sylvan managed design and layout, Adalyn served as acquisitions and managing editor, and Truman handled copyediting and fact-checking. As Burnett et al., cited in Johnson-Eilola & Selber, explain, “Collaboration is rhetorical, collaboration is a process, and collaboration is multimodal” (2013, p. 457). It involves meaningful interactions among individuals who share common goals and exchange information using various tools and in diverse settings (2019, p. 458).

Each role was essential, ensuring the publication’s content, structure, and presentation met our standards through effective collaboration.

Johnson-Eilola and Selber suggests that an effective project management heuristic involves creating a chart that outlines key phases such as planning, research, and information gathering. They explain that the planning phase typically concludes with an information or documentation plan. This plan defines the project’s goals, identifies key tasks, and provides initial estimates for timelines and milestones, including draft review dates and the final document’s completion (2013, pp. 310, 317).

Structured timelines ensured we stayed on track throughout the project by mapping on a Gantt chart. This division of labor highlighted the collaborative nature of editing, where individual strengths contributed to a cohesive and polished final product.

See **Fig 1.0** and **Fig 1.1** below on the draft of roles and responsibilities and our Gantt chart schedule for tasks.

Conceptualising a Style Guide

Cunningham et al. explain, “The term *style* has different meanings, or senses, in technical communication. The guidelines may be created by the company for which you work or the industry to which your company belongs. In this sense, the word is often combined with others to form phrases such as *house style*, *style manual*, or *style guide*” (2019, p. 161).

During one of our weekly in-class sessions with Dr. Ross, we were introduced to another essential aspect of editing: creating a Style Guide. Initially unfamiliar with its purpose, I quickly realised its critical importance for any publication. A Style Guide establishes clear policies and procedures for authors, ensuring they understand expectations when contributing to a specific publishing house. It also serves as a valuable resource for editors, providing but not limited to guidelines for grammar and punctuation.

This ensures consistency and clarity across submissions. To deepen our understanding, we were given a copy of the [Auburn Speaks Style Guide](#) to review and discuss. This exercise allowed us to analyse its structure and content, sharing insights into its effectiveness and organisation.

We were intentional about what we wanted our Style Guide to include, ensuring it reflected the team’s goals for the intended publication. As such, we paid particular attention to incorporating the primary style reference, submission and review process, requirements for images, use of numbers, dates, and time, inclusive language, and formatting for paragraph style and organisation.

As we progressed with editing our Style Guide, we recognised its importance in shaping the organisation and coherence of individual submissions within the publication. Cunningham et al. notes, “A document’s organisation should be informed by your analysis of the rhetorical situation, especially your appraisal of the document. Based on the type of document, you may need to edit its organisation to accomplish one or more of the following: harmonize the purposes of the communicator and audience, conform—if appropriate—to genre conventions, comply with the document owner’s or audience’s specifications, follow an established pattern, and improve paragraph unity and coherence” (2019, p. 63).

Having finalised our Style Guide to the satisfaction of the entire team, we moved on to the next step in the publication process: creating a Call for Papers to invite public contributions for our booklet.

See example of Style Guide used for inspiration by our team here:

<https://auburn.app.box.com/file/1646237469187>

Click [here](#) for finalised draft of *PhotoSynthesis* Style Guide.

Creating a Call For Papers

Creating a Call for Papers (CFP) is a strategic process that involves clearly defining the purpose, scope, and audience of the intended publication. Crafting a CFP requires careful attention to clarity and precision to attract quality submissions while minimising confusion. It is crucial to identify the target audience—such as academics, or industry professionals—and specify the types of contributions expected, including research papers, case studies, or creative projects.

Additionally, a well-planned timeline is essential to provide potential contributors with adequate time to prepare and submit their work. Equally important is fostering inclusivity by encouraging diverse perspectives and promoting the CFP through relevant channels, such as academic networks, social media, and community spaces.

For our CFP, we distributed physical copies to local coffee shops, bookstores, and on bulletin boards within the English department. We also shared a digital version through a popular student social media platform, GroupMe. Despite these efforts, we did not receive the anticipated volume of responses. Frustrated, we sought guidance from Dr. Ross, who recommended redesigning the CFP to make it more concise and engaging, better capturing the attention of our intended audience.

Additionally, a breakdown in communication within our team resulted in an unapproved version of the CFP being distributed prematurely. This oversight may have hindered our initial goal of attracting volunteer contributors, ultimately impacting the success of our CFP.

See below **Fig 1.2** of first CFP distributed and **Fig 1.3** of the revised version CFP

Fig 1.2

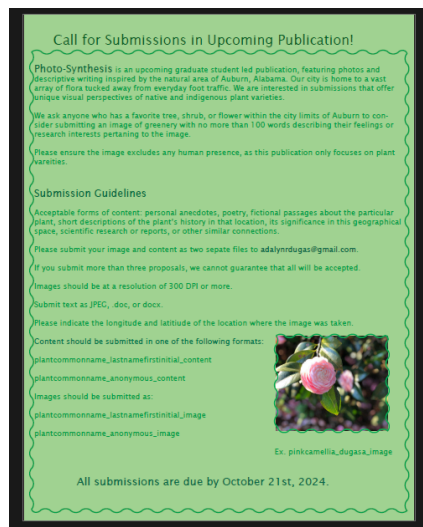


Fig 1.3



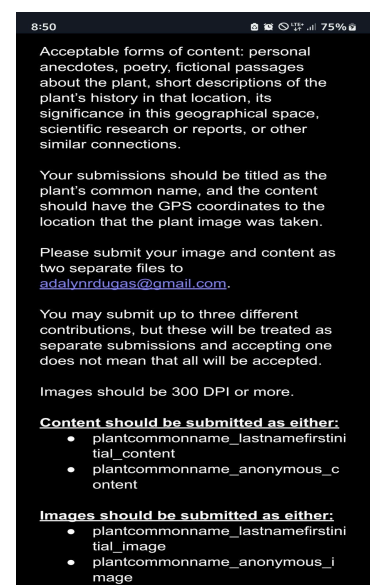
Team members Adalyn and Sylvan redesigned and redistributed the CFP with an extended deadline, a decision unanimously supported by the team. From that experience, I learned that while a well-crafted CFP serves as a clear roadmap for contributors, shaping the quality and diversity of submissions, its design and submission requirements are equally crucial for success.

Submission Review Process

We decided to request a specific content submission format from contributors to ensure all content was easily accessible. Cunningham et.al explains, “That content is information that is valuable and usable by people. And that information is valuable when it’s relevant to the user’s needs and enables a user to understand a certain concept or accomplish a desired task” (2013 p. 255).

All our content submissions were directed to our acquisitions editor, Adalyn, for initial review. Ultimately, the entire team reviewed the submitted works collectively. The illustration on the right shows our CFP requirements.

A unique challenge in acquiring content for this publication was the limited number of public submissions. To address this, we reached out to class colleagues, who kindly contributed pieces in exchange for our editorial assistance on their project.



While this approach was relatively successful; however, each team member also contributed original pieces, including short stories, prose, poems, and photographs, accompanied by location details. These submissions required additional fact-checking and editing to ensure accuracy. We collaboratively reviewed and refined one another's work, combining external contributions with our own efforts to achieve the publication's goals for quality and consistency.

The following outlines the review process we implemented to manage submissions:

Submission Acknowledgment

Upon receiving a submission, contributors received a confirmation email acknowledging receipt. This email outlined the next steps and an estimated timeline for feedback.

Initial Screening

All initial submissions were reviewed by the acquisitions editor to ensure they met basic guidelines, such as adherence to the required format, word count, and compliance with the publication's theme. Submissions that did not meet these requirements were to be returned for revisions or rejected outright.

Assignment to Reviewers

Eligible submissions were reviewed by myself and Truman, we then evaluated the submissions based on predefined criteria, such as originality, clarity, relevance, and quality of content.

Evaluation and Feedback

After completing our reviews, we provided detailed feedback that highlighted strengths, identified areas for improvement, and included recommendations for one of the following actions:

- Accept with minor or no revisions
- Revise and resubmit (major revisions required)
- Reject the submission

Editorial Decision/ Final Approval

As the editorial team, we collaboratively completed a final round of proofreading and formatting to ensure consistency and quality. We then communicated the finalised edits to the design and layout editor, enabling the content to be integrated into the booklet.

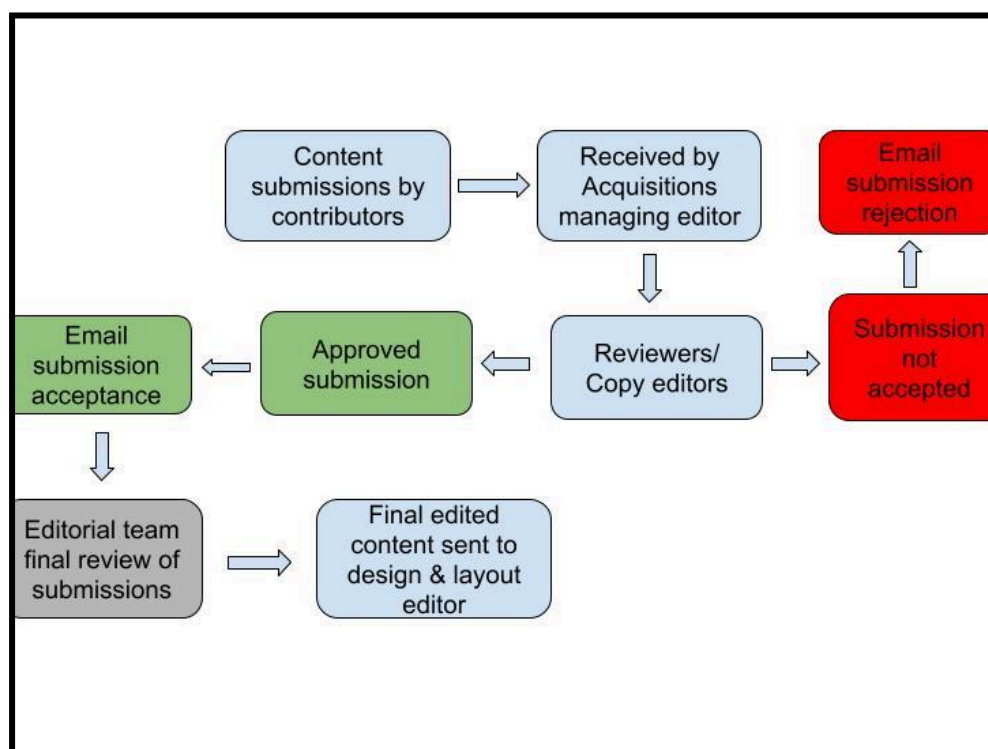
Notification and Publication

Contributors were informed of their acceptance and provided with the publication schedule. The final versions of accepted submissions were then prepared for publication.

This process ensured fairness, transparency, and a commitment to maintaining high standards, resulting in a publication that reflected the best contributions from its authors.

See **Fig 1.4** Chart below on our submission review process

Fig1. 4 Submission Review Process



Design and Layout

The team engaged in thoughtful discussions about the appropriate level of design for the publication. As Kimball and Hawkins observe, “Some documents are simply worthy of a higher design investment than other documents,” with the level of design depending on the time, budget, and purpose (2007, p. 34). While we acknowledged the constraints of our limited resources, we remained committed to delivering a professional, user-friendly final product.

The layout design for our publication was a central focus throughout our weekly team meetings. Sylvan, our design and layout editor, led the process by managing the placement of text, images, and other key elements, while we collaborated to refine the overall design. I contributed submitting suggestions for typography, color schemes, and layout concepts on our shared cloud platform, ensuring our collective vision resonated with the target audience.

We prioritised practical design choices that enhanced usability. For example, we incorporated high-quality color photographs and an interactive map to help readers identify and locate the plants featured in the publication.

We also adapted our vision for the booklet’s paper to include note-taking sections, moving away from the initially envisioned glossy magazine finish to better meet the needs of our audience. Additionally, we prioritised ensuring that our publication was accessible and vision-friendly for online readers. Opeppard and Rabby, as cited in Lancaster & King, highlights that “All media systems tend to favour some types of people over others, through the choices made by the designers” (2024, p.273). This further emphasised the importance of thoughtfully selecting a color palette and text styles to support individuals with visual impairments, thereby enhancing readability for a diverse audience.

Our design process began with mockups and sketches created by Sylvan, which were later refined and transformed into polished designs using Adobe InDesign. To strengthen our skills with this software, Dr. Ross assigned a practice task: designing a tri-fold brochure. This exercise proved useful in understanding the layout techniques used in creating a print publication.

See **Fig 1.5** on layout concepts and **Fig 1.6** on mockup booklet

Fig 1.5

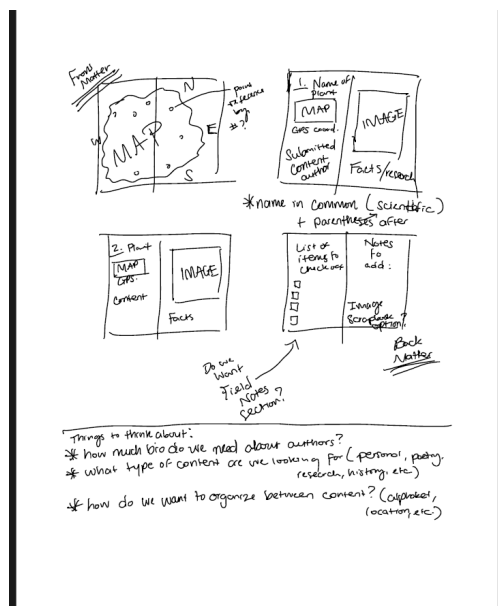


Fig 1.6



Both low-fidelity and high-fidelity testing were integral to the design phase of the publication. As Mirel, cited in Johnson-Eilola and Selber, asserts, “Presenting information to an audience doesn’t guarantee they will value or understand and use it effectively” (2013, p. 285).

She further emphasises, “Once artifacts are in audiences’ hands, it is also important to evaluate whether evolving use signals a corresponding need to add improvements” (2013, p. 285). Engaging with the audience during this phase was crucial for gathering feedback on the booklet’s usability, readability, and overall design. This iterative testing process proved highly effective, enabling us to identify and refine problematic areas, ultimately enhancing the publication’s quality and functionality. See [here](#) for test and results.

Final Proofreading

Cunningham et al. notes, “That drafts are provisional versions of documents, subject to revision (2019, p.122. Feedback from the usability test proved to be essential in gathering information on what the user's experience with a prototype of the booklet was like. We held a final meeting to address the issues users encountered with the booklet and brainstorm potential solutions. One immediate concern was the unclear placement of the map, which made it difficult for users to identify plant locations. To address this, we decided to include QR codes in sections where content was overly complex or unclear to our audience. Cunningham further notes, “ To appraise the completeness of a document, you will need to analyse the rhetorical situation, especially the audience (2019, p.122).

The feedback we received proved invaluable throughout this process. Additionally, we bought a draft version of the booklet to class for peer review, incorporating the corrections and suggestions provided by our peers to enhance the final product.

Distribution of a Completed Booklet

As an editor, seeing a project progress from concept to a completed booklet is immensely fulfilling. However, the work doesn't end with production—distribution is a vital phase that ensures efforts reach the intended audience and make the desired impact.

Dr. Ross guided us through an in-class exercise to explore how publications are distributed across different channels, including print and eBook formats. The first step in distribution was identifying the most effective channels. For our booklet, we aimed to balance physical and digital strategies to maximise outreach. Our approach included creating a finalised, accessible PDF version for online sharing through social media platforms, and online communities to reach a broader audience. Additionally, we prepared a printed version to present as part of our final class project.

We coordinated on having our final edited document to be printed at a local Office Depot. Reflecting on the process, I learned that effective distribution requires careful planning, adaptability, and a clear understanding of the target audience. As an editor, it's gratifying to know that our work is accessible and impactful, connecting with readers in meaningful ways. This phase solidifies the purpose of our publication and validates the collaborative effort behind it.

Review and Conclusion

The process of producing a publication in an editing class from concept to a finished booklet has been incredibly rewarding. Combining theoretical concepts learned in class with hands-on, heuristic learning was essential to my growth and understanding throughout this course.

This project required us to navigate the complexities of editorial workflows, from defining the audience, creating a Mission Statement and Call for Papers to managing roles like substantive editing, copy editing, author, layout design, and fact-checking. Along the way, I gained a deeper appreciation for the collaborative nature of publishing and the meticulous attention to detail required to maintain quality and consistency.

The process highlighted several vital learning outcomes that are directly transferable to the professional world. We developed essential project management skills, such as setting timelines, delegating tasks, and meeting deadlines. We also honed our ability to communicate effectively within a team, an indispensable skill in the workplace. Additionally, the experience reinforced the importance of creating clear, user-friendly resources like Style Guides and Call for Papers, which are critical in ensuring that contributions align with publication goals.

Most importantly, we learned to adapt to challenges, such as redesigning materials or addressing communication breakdowns. These problem-solving skills are invaluable in an industry where deadlines and expectations often shift. Overall, this hands-on project equipped us with a robust foundation in editorial practices, preparing us to navigate the dynamic demands of the editing world with confidence.

Click [here](#) for PDF copy of *PhotoSynthesis*

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